

# Managing boundaries between work and non-work domains: Personality and job characteristics and adopted style

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With an increasing overlap between the work and non-work domain, more research is needed to understand the factors that relate to how individuals manage their boundaries across multiple roles (i.e., work roles, family roles). Using a sample of 498 individuals, we explored the relationships between personality, O\*NET job characteristic variables, and boundary management styles. Results revealed that job responsibility and work structure related to cross-role interruptions and work identity centrality. Further, conscientiousness was related to greater perceptions of boundary control, family identity centrality, and fewer interruptions of work, while neuroticism was related to fewer interruptions of non-work. Finally, the present findings replicated four of six defined boundary management styles put forth in prior research. Theoretical and practical implications are discussed.

## Practitioner points

- Individuals may differ in how they enact boundaries between work and non-work as related to their individual personality.
- The job in which one works may relate to the manner in which boundaries between work and non-work are managed.
- Organizational efforts to help employees with boundary management may be improved if job context and employee individual differences are noted and accommodated.

Over the past few decades, there has been an increasing overlap between work and non-work domains given the rise of new technologies, flexible work arrangements, and telecommuting (Allen, Cho, & Meier, 2014). With the COVID-19 global pandemic, an even greater focus has emerged on these topics as many individuals were forced to work from home (Rudolph et al., 2020). As a result, there has been growing interest in how employees approach boundary management (Allen et al., 2014; Kreiner, Hollensbe, & Sheep, 2009; Matthews & Barnes-Farrell, 2010; Matthews, Barnes-Farrell, & Bulger, 2010; Paustian-Underdahl, Halbesleben, Carlson & Kacmar, 2016). Boundary management

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styles are defined as the techniques employees use to separate roles in order to attend to work, family, and non-work duties (Kossek & Lautsch, 2012). For example, some employees may engage in segmenting their work and home domains, with strict separation of work hours and location from other aspects of their lives (whether working inside or outside of one's home); others may engage in greater integration, switching back and forth between activities and roles, blurring professional relationships with non-work events and relationships. Prior research shows that boundary management styles impact both work and health-related outcomes including work-to-family and family-to-work conflict (Kossek, Lautsch, & Eaton, 2006; Matthews et al., 2010), psychological distress, turnover (Kossek et al., 2006), and well-being (Wepfer, Allen, Brauchli, Jenny & Bauer, 2018).

Despite the link between boundary management styles and important outcomes, theory and empirical research in this area does not provide a lot of insight into which factors and characteristics relate to the boundary management behaviours one adopts. Although researchers agree that individuals differ in how they manage their work and home life (Ammons, 2013; Bulger, Matthews, & Hoffman, 2007; Kossek, Ruderman, Braddy, & Hamm, 2012; Sturges, 2012) and there is considerable research on what drives individual preferences as to how to manage boundaries (Kreiner et al., 2009), there are few studies exploring other factors that influence individuals' boundary management (e.g., Chakrabarti, 2008; Thompson, Beavais & Lyness, 1999). While boundary theory delineates what boundaries are and their properties (Ashforth, Kreiner & Fugate, 2000), it provides minimal theoretical guidance as to inhibitors and facilitators of patterns of cross-boundary micro transitions. That is, are boundary management styles related to inherent employee individual differences? To what extent do work characteristics relate to the manner in which someone manages their work and non-work boundaries? At a practical level, without knowing relative influences and correlates of boundary management behaviours, it is challenging to build family-friendly policies that meet employee needs, for supervisors to most effectively support employees' choices in boundary management, or to provide advice or training to employees who struggle with boundary management.

Therefore, the primary aim of this study is to extend boundary theory and prior research on boundary styles. While boundary theory (Ashforth, Kreiner, & Fugate, 2000) acknowledges the difficulty of transitioning between roles, it says little regarding why this difficulty exists. We put forth job characteristics and personality as two factors that can inhibit role transitions and contribute to this difficulty, and in doing so, we provide theoretical insight into what maintains patterns of boundary management. Further, this study is in line with Allen et al.'s (2014) call for the use of multisource data to understand what impacts the enactment of boundary management strategies, as we use job-level information from O\*NET in addition to self-reported personality and boundary management data.

A secondary aim is to increase understanding of the nuances in how individuals manage boundaries beyond the broad differentiation of segmenting and integrating. Kossek, Ruderman, Braddy, and Hannum (2012) suggested six different styles of boundary management when one considers control, interruptions, and role centrality; however, these were derived in a managerial sample and their applicability to a broader swath of jobs and contexts has not been evaluated. The work-life literature has been critiqued for an overreliance on educated, white-collar samples (Cowan & Bochantin, 2011; Grandey, Cordeiro, & Michael, 2007). We provide that broader evaluation here.

After a brief overview of boundary theory and research on boundary management, we present hypotheses regarding how individual and contextual characteristics are expected

to relate to boundary management styles. We then present a study using a sample of employees in a diverse set of jobs where we test the hypotheses regarding correlates of boundary management behaviours, as well as consider whether prior work on style clusters generalizes beyond managerial workers.

### **Boundary management**

According to boundary theory (Ashforth et al., 2000; Nippert-Eng, 1996), individuals construct and maintain boundaries between life domains as a way to simplify their environment. Boundaries refer to, '...the physical, temporal, emotional, cognitive, and/or relational limits that define entities as separate from one another' (Ashforth et al., 2000, p. 474). Nippert-Eng (1996) established these boundaries as idiosyncratically constructed; that is, although domains (work, home) are based on a shared consensus, the boundaries themselves are created and maintained by individuals. In their articulation of boundary theory, Ashforth et al. (2000) note that the process of making micro role transitions (i.e., crossing boundaries) is affected by flexibility and permeability of the boundaries. They note that when roles are highly differentiated (high contrast), tied to specific settings and times (inflexible) and permit few cross-role interruptions (impermeable), there will be few micro transitions as compared to the converse (i.e., low contrast flexible, permeable). Boundaries can be created along a continuum from 'thin' (weak) to 'thick' (strong), where thin boundaries are permeable and open to integration, whereas thick boundaries are typically closed to influence and segmented (Ashforth et al., 2000; Kreiner et al., 2009; Nippert-Eng, 1996).

There are a number of related terms within the broader boundary management literature that require conceptual delineation as they are often not clearly distinguished. *Boundary management preferences* reflect the manner in which an individual desires to manage their boundaries (Kossek et al., 2006; Kreiner et al., 2009); that is, individuals may prefer to enact rigid versus permeable boundaries between work and non-work life if allowed the choice, such as not checking emails outside of 9–5 hrs or not discussing work challenges with family. However, given contextual and situational restrictions, one might not be able to enact behaviours in direct accordance with preferences, such as when one is expected to finish up work rather than having a set end time. Accordingly, *boundary management behaviors* represent the actual, enacted actions one takes to manage their boundaries between roles, which may or may not be in line with one's boundary management preferences. The concept of *boundary management styles* is defined in a more nebulous way and has been positioned as a person's 'approach' or 'technique' to manage role boundaries (Kossek et al., 2012). The work on boundary styles focuses on the combination of specific enacted behaviours, values, and perceptions (delineated below) as comprising a style or an approach to managing boundary management. The present work focuses on these enacted styles to manage boundaries.

In order to better describe various boundary management styles, Kossek et al. (2012) focused on three characteristics as essential to work–non-work boundary management: cross-role interruption behaviours, identity centrality of work and family roles, and perceived control of boundaries. *Cross-role interruption behaviors* refer to the degree to which individuals allow interruptions across roles. For example, interruptions of work<sup>1</sup>

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<sup>1</sup> Kossek et al. (2012) referred to these as *non-work interrupting work behaviors* (and the converse as *work interrupting non-work behaviors*); we chose to use more concise terms.

occur when individuals' personal and family lives interfere with their work lives, such as personal calls during the workday. Interruptions of non-work, on the other hand, occur when individuals' work lives interfere with their personal and family life outside of the office. An example would be checking work emails during non-work hours (Kossek et al., 2012). Such interruptions may not necessarily be preferred or welcomed, but allowed by the individual. These behaviours fall on a continuum from segmentation, where work and non-work roles are highly separated with few interruptions, to integration, where work and non-work roles are frequently combined and overlap (Kossek et al., 2012). When there is integration between roles, the degree of cross-role interruption behaviours may be symmetrical or asymmetrical. Symmetrical interruption behaviours occur if individuals allow work to interrupt their non-work life and non-work to interrupt their work life equally. Asymmetrical interruption would occur when one domain tends to interrupt the other more often.

The second characteristic Kossek et al. (2012) noted as important to boundary management style is *role centrality*: the value an individual places on one or more of their identities. Typically, the value is determined through the time and energy invested in a particular role (Thoits, 1991). Work identity centrality refers to the extent to which individuals identify with their career or occupation (i.e., lawyer, doctor), whereas family identity centrality refers to the degree to which individuals identify with their family roles (sibling, parent; Kossek et al., 2012). Individuals with dual centrality view their job and family roles as having equal meaning and focus; of note, this can mean neither role is very central.

The third characteristic, *boundary control perceptions*, refers to an individual's perception that they have control over the ability to cross from one role to the other (Kossek et al., 2012). Boundary control perceptions are based on individuals' psychological interpretation of control. When individuals have high perceived boundary control, they believe they can control the frequency and direction of boundary crossings and interruptions in a way that aligns with their needs and identities. When individuals have low perceived boundary control, they do not believe they have control over boundary crossings (Kossek et al., 2012).

Recognizing the importance of each of these characteristics in understanding how individuals manage work and non-work boundaries, we sought to examine whether certain individual and contextual factors were associated with how boundaries between work and non-work are managed. That is, do certain jobs lead to greater interruptions or lower perceived control, thus constraining how individuals can manage boundaries? Further, do certain personality characteristics relate to allowing or preventing interruptions, making a role more central, or perceiving more or less control? Below we detail hypotheses surrounding two job factors (i.e., job responsibility and structure) and two individual characteristics (i.e., conscientiousness and neuroticism) that are anticipated to influence approaches to boundary management Table 1.

### ***Job responsibility, work structure, and boundary management***

A core concept in boundary theory is the continuum of boundary thickness (Ashforth et al., 2000) and situational strength is posited as a key influence on boundary creation and maintenance. While it may be intuitive that characteristics of one's job may influence boundary thickness (and one of Ashforth et al's propositions suggests this), little research

**Table 1.** Kossek et al.'s (2012) boundary management profiles

| Profile              | Boundary control | Cross-role interruptions                                                       | Identity centrality            |
|----------------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| Work warriors        | Low              | Asymmetrical with high interruptions of non-work                               | Work centric                   |
| Overwhelmed reactors | Low              | Symmetrical with high interruption behaviours in both directions               | Dual centric (work and family) |
| Family guardians     | High             | Asymmetrical with high interruptions of work                                   | Dual centric (work and family) |
| Fusion lovers        | High             | Symmetrical with high interruption behaviours in both directions               | Dual centric (work and family) |
| Dividers             | High             | Symmetrical with low interruption behaviours in both directions                | Dual centric (work and family) |
| Non-work eclectics   | High             | Symmetrical with moderate levels of interruption behaviours in both directions | Work centric                   |

has focused on delineating specific job characteristics associated with boundary strength. Job demands, broadly defined, may necessitate greater interruptions of non-work (e.g., being on call), may limit interruptions of work (e.g., bus drivers cannot answer their cell), and may influence perceptions of control over one's time and focus. Indeed, prior meta-analytic work has demonstrated that job flexibility and higher autonomy at work relate to having less work–family conflict (Liao, Lau, Hui, & Kong, 2019). Thus, in boundary theory terms, job characteristics can impact boundary flexibility and permeability.

More specifically, the extent to which there is high responsibility for outcomes of others may influence one's ability and approach to manage boundaries. Typically, jobs with high responsibility require greater accountability and job involvement on the part of the employee (Dierdorff & Ellington, 2008). When individuals have high accountability for outcomes, they may have to attend to work during non-work periods. Indeed, Dierdorff and Ellington (2008) found that having high responsibility for others at work was positively related to work-family conflict. In addition, having high responsibility and impact may influence an individual's job involvement, and subsequently, their perceptions of work identity centrality. Diefendorff et al. (2002) found that job involvement was positively and significantly related to work centrality. Further, it may also be the case that for those with high work centrality, pursuing and being promoted in jobs that entail greater responsibility may be more likely than for those who see work as less central to their lives. However, we did not expect greater or less frequent interruptions of work or family centrality to differ based on levels of job responsibilities, as the job itself would not affect what emanates from the non-work domain. Therefore, we hypothesize the following:

*Hypothesis 1.* Individuals in jobs with high responsibility for outcomes will report (a) less perceived boundary control, (b) greater work identity centrality, and (c) more frequent interruptions of non-work as compared to those with less responsibility for outcomes.

Further, the extent to which the job is unstructured for the individual, meaning the extent to which the individual has the autonomy to determine tasks, priorities and goals, may also influence boundary management style. When individuals do not have structured job priorities, they will likely be less impacted by cross-role interruptions because they are able to determine what gets done and how. In their articulation of boundary theory, Ashforth et al. (2000) specifically proposed that the affective impact of cross-role interruptions is less when boundaries are more flexible and permeable. Having less structure and greater autonomy can allow individuals to attend to their work duties in a way that does not conflict with their other roles. This is consistent with prior research findings displaying a negative relationship between job autonomy and work–family conflict (Ahuja, McKnight, Chudoba, George, & Kacmar, 2007; Thompson & Prottas, 2005). Individuals with less structured work environments may perceive more boundary control when they have more agency over what they do and when and how they do it. Similarly, Thompson and Prottas (2005) found that job autonomy was positively related to perceived life control. Although it is likely that unstructured work influences one's perception of cross-role interruptions and perceived boundary control, there is no reason to suggest that work structure would influence work or family identity centrality to a greater or lesser extent. Accordingly, we expect:

*Hypothesis 2.* Individuals who have more structured work will report (a) less perceived boundary control, (b) more frequent interruptions of non-work, and (c) more frequent interruptions of work than will individuals with less structured work.

### **Personality and boundary management**

Boundary theory (Ashforth et al., 2000) holds that individuals construct and maintain boundaries between domains; however, the theory itself does not articulate how individual behavioural tendencies (i.e., personality) impact that construction or maintenance. While boundary theory does suggest that boundary strength may be driven by the work situation, it does not specify that individual characteristics have an influence on flexibility and permeability, yet the work-life literature does suggest that possibility. Indeed, prior research has found personality characteristics such as conscientiousness and neuroticism to relate to the level and nature of work–non-work conflict (Bruck & Allen, 2003; Wayne, Musica & Fleeson, 2004). Further, boundary management preferences are a widely studied individual difference (Bogaerts, De Cooman, & De Gieter, 2018; Kreiner et al., 2009; Paustian-Underdahl, Haldesleben, Carlson, & Kacmar, 2016) which is likely influenced by one's personality, although researchers have not studied those connections.

We expect that conscientiousness will be related to greater perceived boundary control and work identity centrality, as well as fewer cross-role interruptions. Conscientiousness predicts job performance (Barrick & Mount, 1991), and individuals high in conscientiousness tend to have more organizational advancement (Judge, Bono, Ilies, & Gerhardt, 2002) perhaps due to their increased job involvement and organizational commitment (Kostek, 2012), which could relate to their work identity (while having no clear bearing on family role centrality). Furthermore, prior research found a significant, positive relationship between conscientiousness, job involvement, and work centrality (Christopher, Zabel, & Jones, 2008; Diefendorff, Brown, Kamin, & Lord, 2002), as did Kostek's (2012) meta-analytic investigation of work centrality antecedents. Individuals high in conscientiousness tend to be methodical and deliberate in their actions (Ozer & Benet-Martínez, 2006) and thus are likely to be effective at managing their time, responsibilities, and tasks across roles, and particularly so for roles with high centrality. While research has indicated that conscientious workers do attend to interruptions (e.g., emails) *within* the work domain (e.g., Russell, Wood & Banks, 2017), conscientiousness about attending to the work role should make them more diligent in preventing interruptions from other domains. In this way, 'allowed' interruptions may indeed be less likely to be permitted by conscientious individuals. Finally, Hattrup, O'Connell, and Labrador (2005) found a significant, positive relationship between conscientiousness and locus of control, which likely impacts perceptions of boundary control. Therefore, we predict:

*Hypothesis 3.* Individuals high in conscientiousness will (a) perceive greater control over boundaries, (b) report greater work identity centrality, and (c) report less frequent interruptions of non-work and (d) report less frequent interruptions of work above and beyond effects of job context.

Another personality characteristic likely to relate to an employee's boundary management above and job requirements is neuroticism. Individuals high in neuroticism tend to be emotionally reactive (Ozer & Benet-Martínez, 2006), and neuroticism has been found to significantly relate to negative work-to-family and family-to-work spillover (Grzywacz & Marks, 2000) and positively to work-family conflict (Bruck & Allen, 2003; Wayne, Musisca, & Fleeson, 2004). Individuals high in neuroticism tend to worry (Keogh, French, & Reidy, 1998; Muris, Roelofs, Rassin, Franken, & Mayer, 2005) and may consequently be less efficient with their time due to concern for aspects outside their critical tasks, potentially drawing away needed attention from such duties. For these reasons, they may experience greater cross-role interruptions, as they may be too worried or anxious to draw boundaries and refuse interruptions. They also may be crunched for time and subsequently face increased time pressure, which lends itself to more role spanning and boundary crossings (Syrek, Apostel, & Antoni, 2013; Thompson, Beauvais, & Lyness, 1999). Individuals high in neuroticism are also likely to experience less perceived boundary control, based on their emotional reactivity and instability. We did not, however, expect neuroticism to relate to the centrality of either role. Accordingly, we hypothesize:

*Hypothesis 4.* Individuals high in neuroticism will report (a) less perceived boundary control, (b) more frequent interruptions of non-work, and (c) more frequent interruptions of work above and beyond the effects of job context.

### ***Replication of boundary management style clusters***

In addition to our examination of the relationships between work context and personality variables with various aspects of boundary management, we further sought to replicate the boundary management style clusters proposed by Kossek et al. (2012). In their study, Kossek et al. (2012) identified six clusters based on patterns of the three boundary management characteristics of present focus (cross-role interruption behaviours, role centrality, and boundary control perceptions). For example, one cluster was labelled 'dividers' which referred to individuals that have high perceptions of boundary control, low cross-role interruption behaviours, and role centrality shared between work and family. Another cluster, 'family guardians', also has high perceptions of boundary control, dual centric identity, but unlike dividers, they experience asymmetrical cross-role interruptions with more interruptions of work. See Table 2 for the full description of all six clusters from Kossek et al. (2012).

While these six styles have intuitive appeal, researchers have not considered whether they are broadly adopted as they were established with a managerial sample. It may be that those in other positions show different patterns of boundary management. For example, blue collar workers may have lower work centrality and lower interruptions of non-work relative to managers; professional individual contributors may tend to have higher control perceptions than many managers. Assessing the generalizability of the clusters to a more representative work force than that used in development of the taxonomy is useful for understand boundary management. Thus, we examined:

*Research Question:* Do the boundary management style clusters proposed by Kossek et al. (2012) replicate?



**Table 2.** Hypothesized relationships between personality and job characteristic variables and boundary management behaviours

|                                  | Boundary control | Work identity centrality | Interruptions of non-work | Interruptions of work | Family identity centrality |
|----------------------------------|------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------------|----------------------------|
| H1: Responsibility for outcomes: | Negative         | Positive                 | Positive                  | N/A                   | N/A                        |
| H2: Work structure:              | Negative         | N/A                      | Positive                  | Positive              | N/A                        |
| H3: Conscientiousness:           | Positive         | Positive                 | Negative                  | Negative              | N/A                        |
| H4: Neuroticism:                 | Negative         | N/A                      | Positive                  | Positive              | N/A                        |

**Table 3.** Descriptive statistics and intercorrelations for personality, job characteristics, boundary management, and controls

|                               | 1           | 2           | 3           | 4           | 5           | 6           | 7           | 8           | 9           | 10          | 11          | 12         | 13   |
|-------------------------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|-------------|------------|------|
| 1 Responsibility for outcomes | (-)         |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 2 Unstructured work           | <b>.48</b>  | (-)         |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 3 Neuroticism                 | <b>-.10</b> | <b>-.04</b> | (.88)       |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 4 Conscientiousness           | <b>-.11</b> | <b>-.10</b> | <b>-.31</b> | (.71)       |             |             |             |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 5 Interruptions of work       | <b>.05</b>  | <b>.12</b>  | <b>.14</b>  | <b>-.22</b> | (.75)       |             |             |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 6 Interruptions of non-work   | <b>.22</b>  | <b>.16</b>  | <b>-.12</b> | <b>-.07</b> | <b>.13</b>  | (.86)       |             |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 7 Boundary control            | <b>-.03</b> | <b>-.04</b> | <b>-.13</b> | <b>.18</b>  | <b>-.02</b> | <b>-.23</b> | (.69)       |             |             |             |             |            |      |
| 8 Work identity centrality    | <b>.13</b>  | <b>.09</b>  | <b>-.10</b> | <b>.09</b>  | <b>-.11</b> | <b>.37</b>  | <b>.09</b>  | (-)         |             |             |             |            |      |
| 9 Family identity centrality  | <b>.00</b>  | <b>-.03</b> | <b>-.16</b> | <b>.17</b>  | <b>.08</b>  | <b>-.08</b> | <b>.21</b>  | <b>.14</b>  | (-)         |             |             |            |      |
| 10 Gender                     | <b>-.17</b> | <b>-.09</b> | <b>.13</b>  | <b>.09</b>  | <b>-.07</b> | <b>-.09</b> | <b>.05</b>  | <b>-.02</b> | <b>.05</b>  | (-)         |             |            |      |
| 11 Children under 18 at home  | <b>.13</b>  | <b>.05</b>  | <b>-.17</b> | <b>.03</b>  | <b>.03</b>  | <b>.09</b>  | <b>-.07</b> | <b>.03</b>  | <b>.22</b>  | <b>-.09</b> | (-)         |            |      |
| 12 Age                        | <b>.27</b>  | <b>.18</b>  | <b>-.24</b> | <b>-.04</b> | <b>.02</b>  | <b>.25</b>  | <b>-.13</b> | <b>.01</b>  | <b>-.01</b> | <b>-.16</b> | <b>.37</b>  | (-)        |      |
| 13 Living with spouse         | <b>-.18</b> | <b>-.10</b> | <b>.23</b>  | <b>-.02</b> | <b>-.03</b> | <b>-.12</b> | <b>.03</b>  | <b>-.06</b> | <b>-.15</b> | <b>-.13</b> | <b>-.38</b> | <b>.32</b> | (-)  |
| M                             | 3.48        | 4.31        | 6.72        | 9.71        | 2.64        | 1.99        | 2.79        | 3.06        | 3.14        | 1.42        | 0.16        | 34.8       | 0.45 |
| SD                            | 0.69        | 0.36        | 5.42        | 2.88        | 0.76        | 0.97        | 0.78        | 0.72        | 0.89        | 0.49        | 0.95        | 7.50       | 0.69 |

Note.. Bolded values are significant at  $p < .05$ . Reliabilities presented in parentheses.

## Methods

### Sample

To address our present hypotheses and research question, we obtained data from two sources. First, we gathered personality and boundary management data from 498 individuals. While individuals were located in 22 countries, the vast majority (over 90%) were from North America (e.g., 79.7% United States, 10.6% Canada) and all surveys were administered in English. Study participation was offered to those taking an online personality assessment used for work- and career-related development purposes; specifically, 37.8% reported taking the assessment for personal professional development, 36.5% for professional team building purposes, 9.0% for career guidance, 6.0% as part of a selection/hiring process, 4.2% as a part of a post-hire process, and 6.2% for some other reason. Data for this study were collected through an optional follow-up survey that individuals were invited to voluntarily complete after finishing their primary assessment, and all data were collected prior to the COVID-19 pandemic.

The sample was 41.6% female and 67.1% were living with their spouse/partner. 49.8% of respondents had 1 or more child under the age of 18 living at home, and the age of youngest child ranged from less than 12 months old (2.2%) to 21 or older (1.6%). The average age was 34.83 ( $SD = 7.64$ ), and participants were majority White (72.5%; 8.0% Black, 7.7% Asian, 6.7% Latino, 4.1% multiracial, and 1.0% other races). With respect to employment status, 94.8% reported full-time employment, while the remaining 5.2% reported part-time employment. The majority of participants worked in companies with under 1,000 employees (51.4%), while 24.8% were housed in organizations of between 1,000 and 10,000 employees, and 23.7% worked in companies with over 10,000 employees. While the majority of this sample did not work from home (64.6%), 28.6% of participants did telecommute partially, and 7.0% telecommuted full-time. Participants reported working at their current organization for an average of 2.49 years ( $SD = 3.23$ ).

### Boundary management measures

All boundary management variables were assessed via subscales from Kossek et al. (2012) with five-point 'Strongly Disagree' to 'Strongly Agree' Likert-type response options. *Interruptions of work* were measured using five items ( $\alpha = .75$ ). An example item is 'I take care of personal or family needs during work'. *Interruptions of non-work* consisted of five items ( $\alpha = .86$ ). An example item is 'I regularly bring work home'. *Perceived boundary control* was measured using three items ( $\alpha = .79$ ). An example item is 'I

**Table 4.** Job characteristics and personality variables predicting interruptions of non-work

| Model | Variable                    | B     | SE B | $\beta$ | p-value | R <sup>2</sup> |
|-------|-----------------------------|-------|------|---------|---------|----------------|
| 1     | Intercept                   | 0.29  | .52  |         | .58     |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | 0.27  | .07  | .19     | <.001   |                |
|       | Work structure              | 0.18  | .14  | .07     | .190    | .05            |
| 2     | Intercept                   | 0.92  | .57  |         | .108    |                |
|       | Responsibility for Outcomes | 0.24  | .07  | .17     | .001    |                |
|       | Work structure              | 0.17  | .14  | .06     | .214    |                |
|       | conscientiousness           | −0.03 | .02  | −.10    | .041    |                |
|       | Neuroticism                 | −0.02 | .01  | −.13    | .006    | .06            |

**Table 5.** Job characteristics and personality variables predicting interruptions of work

| Model | Variable                    | B     | SE B | $\beta$ | p-value | R <sup>2</sup> |
|-------|-----------------------------|-------|------|---------|---------|----------------|
| 1     | Intercept                   | 1.57  | .42  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | −0.01 | .06  | −.01    | .837    |                |
|       | Work Structure              | 0.26  | .11  | .12     | .022    | .01            |
| 2     | Intercept                   | 2.12  | .46  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | −0.02 | .06  | −.02    | .76     |                |
|       | Work structure              | 0.23  | .11  | .11     | .038    |                |
|       | Conscientiousness           | −0.05 | .01  | −.19    | <.001   |                |
|       | Neuroticism                 | 0.01  | .01  | .09     | .064    | .07            |

**Table 6.** Job characteristics and personality variables predicting perceived boundary control

| Model | Variable                    | B     | SE B | $\beta$ | p-value | R <sup>2</sup> |
|-------|-----------------------------|-------|------|---------|---------|----------------|
| 1     | Intercept                   | 3.13  | .44  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for Outcomes | −0.01 | .06  | −.01    | .827    |                |
|       | Work structure              | −0.07 | .12  | −.03    | .545    | .002           |
| 2     | Intercept                   | 2.69  | .47  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | −0.01 | .06  | −.01    | .859    |                |
|       | Work structure              | −0.05 | .11  | −.02    | .694    |                |
|       | Conscientiousness           | 0.04  | .01  | .15     | .002    |                |
|       | Neuroticism                 | −0.01 | .01  | −.09    | .066    | .04            |

**Table 7.** Job characteristics and personality variables predicting work identity centrality

| Model | Variable                    | B     | SE B | $\beta$ | p-value | R <sup>2</sup> |
|-------|-----------------------------|-------|------|---------|---------|----------------|
| 1     | Intercept                   | 2.32  | .40  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | 0.11  | .06  | .11     | .038    |                |
|       | Work structure              | 0.08  | .11  | .04     | .462    | 0.02           |
| 2     | Intercept                   | 2.13  | .44  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | 0.11  | .06  | .11     | .041    |                |
|       | Work structure              | 0.09  | .10  | .05     | .389    |                |
|       | Conscientiousness           | 0.02  | .01  | .08     | .100    |                |
|       | Neuroticism                 | −0.01 | .01  | −.07    | .168    | 0.03           |

control whether I am able to keep my work and personal life separate'. Though the original subscales consisted of two items each, both *work identity centrality* and *family identity centrality* were measured with one item each (work: 'I invest a large part of myself in my work', family: 'I invest a large part of myself in my family') due to length restrictions in adding research items to the assessment platform. Though the use of single-item measures is critiqued for reliability concerns, research has supported single-item scales for both job-relevant and identity-relevant constructs (e.g., job satisfaction, social identity; Nagy, 2002; Postmes, Haslam, & Jans, 2013; Wanous, Reichers, & Hudy, 1997).

### Job characteristics

We mapped respondent-provided job titles onto job titles from the U.S. Department of Labor's Occupational Information Network (O\*NET) to obtain job characteristic ratings (see Peterson et al., 2001). Three coders—two undergraduate students and one doctoral student—matched job titles to O\*NET job titles. Interrater agreement across raters was high ( $\kappa = .82$ ). Any conflicts in coding were resolved through discussion. Of the 498 individuals, 469 cases were matched to the O\*NET context ratings. Across the sample, there were 182 different jobs held by respondents. Sample jobs include education administrators, credit analysts, mechanical engineers, medical assistants, and firefighters. Only eight occupations contained at least 10 individuals nested within one job, so we did not need to use multilevel modelling approaches with these data.

To assess *structure* of work and *responsibility* for outcomes, we used two job characteristic ratings from the Occupational Information Network (O\*NET). O\*NET was designed to identify job requirements and build job descriptions for training, selection, performance review, compensation, and vocational counselling activities, with the general purpose of using common language across jobs to build a taxonomy of occupation descriptions. The data in O\*NET are regularly updated and collected from job incumbents and job analysts (Peterson et al., 2001).

To assess structure of work, O\*NET used the item 'How much freedom do you have to determine the tasks, priorities, or goals of your current job'? The item was scored on a scale from 1 to 5 where 1 = 'No freedom' and 5 = 'A lot of freedom'. Responsibility for outcomes was measured with the item 'How responsible are you for work outcomes and results of other workers on your current job'? The item was scored on a scale from 1 to 5 where 1 = 'No responsibility' and 5 = 'Very high responsibility'.

### Individual characteristics

Personality was measured using The Birkman Method (Birkman, Elizondo, & Wadlington, 2013). The Birkman Method is an occupational interest and personality assessment that has been validated using factor analysis and item response theory (see Birkman et al., 2013; Birkman International, 2013) and used in a number of research studies (Huang et al., 2015; King et al., 2016; Ott-Holland, Huang, Ryan, Elizondo, & Wadlington, 2013, 2014). The personality section consists of 88 dichotomous items (i.e., True/False with a scoring of '1' for items endorsed as 'True' and '0' for items endorsed as 'False') that are summed to map onto five personality orientations. The Birkman method manual (Birkman et al.,

**Table 8.** Job characteristics and personality variables predicting family identity centrality

| Model | Variable                    | B     | SE B | $\beta$ | p-value | R <sup>2</sup> |
|-------|-----------------------------|-------|------|---------|---------|----------------|
| 1     | Intercept                   | 3.43  | .49  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | 0.02  | .07  | .02     | .747    |                |
|       | Work structure              | -0.08 | .13  | -.03    | .517    | .001           |
| 2     | Intercept                   | 3.06  | .54  |         | <.001   |                |
|       | Responsibility for outcomes | 0.02  | .07  | .01     | .792    |                |
|       | Work structure              | -0.06 | .13  | -.02    | .655    |                |
|       | Conscientiousness           | 0.04  | .02  | .14     | .005    |                |
|       | Neuroticism                 | -0.02 | .01  | -.13    | .010    | .05            |

2013) contains reliability (e.g., test–retest) and validity (e.g., convergent construct validity) evidence for the personality measures.

For analyses, we focused on two personality orientations that relate to Big Five scales (Birkman International, 2013). Neuroticism (emotive orientation) was measured with 22 items ( $\alpha = .88$ ), and conscientiousness (process orientation) was measured using 15 items ( $\alpha = .71$ ). Prior convergent validity evidence suggests process orientation is related to other conscientiousness scales (e.g.,  $r = .63$  with NEO conscientiousness), with emotive orientation having more modest relationships with measures of emotional stability/neuroticism ( $-.30$  and  $.23$  with 16PF stability and NEO neuroticism scales) (see Birkman et al., 2013). Corrected correlations (for attenuation due to unreliability) between emotive orientation and NEO neuroticism have been reported as  $.25$ , and between process orientation and NEO conscientiousness as  $.81$  (Birkman, Elizondo, Lee, Wadlington, & Zamzow, 2008; Ryan, King, Elizondo, & Wadlington, 2020).

### Analytic strategy

To test our hypotheses, we conducted a series of hierarchical regressions with responsibility and work structure included as the first step and conscientiousness and neuroticism added as the second step to examine how personality variables add predictive value beyond variables associated with work context. This approach was selected given the conceptualization of job context as a constraint on worker behaviour (Capsi & Moffit, 1993), potentially limiting the impact of individual differences on work-relevant actions as outlined by situational strength theory (Judge & Zapata, 2015; Mischel, 1977). Further, as boundary theory emphasizes the work context as the driver of boundary strength rather than individual characteristics (Ashforth et al., 2000), the strategy of first inputting context characteristics prior to personality variables is in line with relevant boundary management theory. By including job-relevant variables first, we aimed to understand the role of personality above and beyond these situationally constraining factors.

To address our aim of understanding whether Kossek et al.' (2012) boundary management style clusters generalize, we conducted a cluster analysis in SPSS's K-Means clustering. Finally, to add information as to whether personality and job characteristics varied across these boundary management style profiles, we conducted a MANOVA and a series of follow-up univariate ANOVA's with the management profiles as the factor, and our examined personality and job variables as the outcomes (Table 2).

## Results

Table 3 provides the descriptive statistics and intercorrelations for key study variables, while Table 4 through 7 display the results of the hierarchical regressions conducted to test our hypotheses.

Hypothesis 1 proposed relationships between level of responsibility and boundary management variables. While H1a was not supported given a lack of significant relationship between responsibility of outcomes and boundary control (Table 6;  $\beta = -.01$ ), both H1b and H1c were supported. As predicted, individuals in jobs with high responsibility for outcomes reported greater work identity centrality (Table 7;  $\beta = .11$ ) and more frequent interruptions of non-work (Table 4;  $\beta = .17$ ). Therefore, H1 was partially supported.

**Table 9.** Rescaled relative weights for job characteristics and personality variables predicting boundary management outcomes

| Predictor                   | Interruptions of non-work | Interruptions of work | Boundary control | Work identity centrality | Family identity centrality |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------------|------------------|--------------------------|----------------------------|
| Responsibility for Outcomes | 1.75                      | 51.84                 | 1.13             | 39.45                    | 0.52                       |
| Work structure              | 16.89                     | 20.22                 | 2.12             | 16.01                    | 1.38                       |
| Conscientiousness           | 61.52                     | 7.50                  | 68.92            | 23.71                    | 54.29                      |
| Neuroticism                 | 19.84                     | 20.44                 | 27.84            | 20.83                    | 43.81                      |

Note.. Values in this table are the rescaled relative weights and represent the percentage of predicted variance accounted for in each of the five dependent variables.

**Table 10.** Cluster profiles

|                           |               | Low control profiles                        |                                       | High control profiles |                |                |           |  |  |
|---------------------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|-----------------------|----------------|----------------|-----------|--|--|
|                           |               | Cluster 1                                   | Cluster 2                             | Cluster 3             | Cluster 4      | Cluster 5      | Cluster 6 |  |  |
| <i>moderates</i>          |               |                                             | <i>Personal<br/>life<br/>Flexible</i> |                       |                |                |           |  |  |
|                           |               | Overwhelmed reactors<br><i>prioritizers</i> |                                       |                       |                |                |           |  |  |
|                           |               | Family guardians                            | Fusion<br>lovers                      | Dividers              |                |                |           |  |  |
|                           | <i>n = 65</i> | <i>n = 11</i>                               | <i>n = 50</i>                         | <i>n = 128</i>        | <i>n = 159</i> | <i>n = 115</i> |           |  |  |
| Interruptions of work     |               | 2.77                                        | 2.63                                  | 2.36                  | 3.05           | 2.98           | 1.85      |  |  |
| Interruptions of non-work |               | 2.53                                        | 0.85                                  | 2.61                  | 1.23           | 2.87           | 1.37      |  |  |
| Boundary control          |               | 1.51                                        | 2.03                                  | 2.59                  | 2.99           | 2.99           | 3.22      |  |  |
| Work identity             |               | 3.00                                        | 1.00                                  | 2.00                  | 3.00           | 3.00           | 4.00      |  |  |
| Family identity           |               | 3.00                                        | 1.00                                  | 3.00                  | 3.00           | 3.00           | 3.00      |  |  |

Note.. Replicated clusters are in non-italicized text. Newly proposed cluster names are italicized.



Hypothesis 2 proposed associations between level of work structure and examined boundary management variables. This hypothesis received some support. While neither H2a nor H2b was supported, as relationships between work structure and boundary control (H2a; Table 6;  $\beta = -.03$ ) and interruptions of non-work (H2b; Table 4;  $\beta = .07$ ) were not significant, H2c was supported. As predicted, individuals with more structured work reported more frequent interruptions of work (Table 5;  $\beta = .12$ ); therefore, H2 was partially supported.

Hypothesis 3 predicted relationships between conscientiousness and boundary management measures. This hypothesis was mostly supported; as suggested by H3a, H3c, and H3d (respectively), those high on conscientiousness reported greater boundary control (Table 6;  $\beta = .15$ ), fewer interruptions of non-work (Table 4;  $\beta = -.10$ ), and fewer interruptions of work (Table 5;  $\beta = -.19$ ). However, H2b was not supported, as the relationship between conscientiousness and work identity centrality was not significant (Table 7;  $\beta = .08$ ).

Finally, H4 described proposed associations between neuroticism and boundary management variables. This hypothesis received limited support. The relationships between neuroticism with boundary control (H4a; Table 6;  $\beta = -.09$ ) and interruptions of work (H4c; Table 5;  $\beta = .09$ ) were not significant ( $p = .066, .064$  respectively), although both associations were in the expected direction. Further, a negative association was found between neuroticism and interruptions of non-work (Table 4;  $\beta = -.13$ ), the opposite direction of that proposed in H4b.

Although no explicit hypotheses were made regarding family identity centrality and our examined predictors, Table 8 demonstrates relationships between personality and work context variables with family identity centrality. While neither work context variables were found to predict family identity centrality, both personality variables emerged as significant predictors. Specifically, conscientiousness displayed a positive relationship with family identity centrality ( $\beta = .14$ ), while neuroticism demonstrated a negative association ( $\beta = -.13$ ).

### **Consideration of demographic characteristics**

Considerable attention in work-life literature has been given to if, how, and when personal characteristics such as gender and family structure affect outcomes (see Michel, Kotrba, Mitchelson, Clark, & Baltes, 2011 for a review). While this literature is quite mixed in findings, we considered the following variables for potential relationships with study outcomes: gender, children under 18 at home, age, and whether the employee was living with a spouse. Indeed, none of the examined demographic variables related to interruptions of work or work identity centrality, and no change in findings occurred when considered as controls in analyses for family identity centrality. While personal characteristics did relate to interruption of non-work and boundary control, considering these variables as controls resulted in only two differences. Controlling for gender, age, and children under 18 at home weakened the relationship between personality variables and interruption of non-work (conscientiousness:  $\beta = -.07, p = .12$ ; neuroticism:  $\beta = -.08, p = .08$ ). For boundary control analyses, controlling for age strengthened the relationship between neuroticism and the outcome to significance ( $\beta = -.13, p = .01$ ). Thus, while life circumstances do appear to influence level of interruptions of non-work regardless of one's personality, overall boundary management styles were relatively uninfluenced by personal characteristics.

### **Post hoc relative weights analyses**

In an attempt to understand the relative and comparative influences of job characteristics and personality variables on boundary management outcomes, post hoc relative weights analyses were conducted using the RWA-Web package developed by Tonidandel and LeBreton (2015). This analysis presents rescaled relative weights, otherwise understood as estimates of the per cent of predicted variance in each outcome attributable to each predictor. The unique contribution of relative weights analysis compared to common regression approaches is the provision of accurate effect estimates reflecting the predictive contributions among multicollinear predictors (Johnson, 2000). Further, this approach allows us to understand whether two predictors significantly differ from one another in predictive magnitude.

Table 9 demonstrates the relative weights of each predictor as accounting for the variance in each outcome. Looking to Table 9, personality variables overall account for greater variance in outcomes than do job characteristics except for the case of interruptions of work; however, only targeted comparisons can speak to whether personality and job characteristic variables significantly differ in their predictive magnitude. Accordingly, three targeted comparisons were conducted based on the supported relationships in H1-H4 (i.e. for interruptions of non-work, level of responsibility was compared to both conscientiousness and neuroticism, while structure was compared to conscientiousness for interruptions of work). Bootstrapped confidence intervals show that only one comparison displayed significant differences: conscientiousness was found to be a significantly stronger predictor as compared to level of responsibility on interruptions of non-work (95% CI [0.02, 0.09]). Neither comparison of level of responsibility and neuroticism on interruptions of non-work (95% CI [-0.01, 0.05]), nor the comparison of work structure and conscientiousness on interruptions of work were significant, 95% CI [-0.06, 0.01], indicating that work characteristics and personality were relatively similar in their effects in these instances.

### **Boundary management style clusters**

In order to examine if Kossek et al.'s (2012) boundary management clusters generalized to a sample with greater job diversity, we conducted a cluster analysis in SPSS's K-Means clustering. As is common in cluster analysis techniques, this approach uses squared Euclidean distance to determine similarities of individual profiles on the boundary management characteristics measures (Steinley, 2006). We inputted the boundary management characteristics (cross-role interruptions, role identity centrality, and perceived boundary control) and specified six clusters based on Kossek and colleagues' findings. We replicated four out of the six clusters (see Table 10). That is, a large percentage of the sample showed patterns of fusion lovers (high boundary control, dual centrality, and symmetric cross-role interruptions), family guardians (high boundary control, dual centrality and high interruptions of non-work but not high interruptions of work) and dividers (high boundary control, dual centrality and low interruption in either direction). We also found a cluster similar to Kossek et al.'s overwhelmed reactors (low control, dual centrality, high interruptions in both directions).

One of the two clusters we were unable to replicate was 'work warriors', who display low control, high work identity centrality and work interruption. Our Cluster 2 in Table 10 had low control but might be more aptly described as 'personal life prioritizers' in that they had low centrality for both work and family and high interruptions of work, but not vice versa. This was also the smallest cluster, indicating it to be a less common

style. It may be that work warriors as found in Kossek et al. (2012) are more unique to higher level managerial positions found in their study; our sample contained a range of job types and levels. Further, the small cluster of personal life prioritizers found here who are challenged to keep their non-work life under control may be less prevalent in higher level positions where financial standing affords more options for childcare and handling non-work challenges (Kossek & Lautsch, 2018; Michel et al., 2011). However, these are post hoc speculations that await further exploration.

We also did not find a cluster similar to Kossek et al.'s 'non-work eclectics' who had high interruptions in both directions, high boundary control, but a low family identity centrality. Our Cluster 3 in Table 10 had moderate boundary control, a slightly lower work than family identity centrality, relatively low interruption of work but higher interruption of non-work. Once again, having a sample that is not solely managerial led to more individuals with lower work centrality, but in this case, their non-work life is not as interfering as it is for Cluster 2 – perhaps these are best labelled as 'flexible moderates'.

### **Boundary management styles, job characteristics, and personality**

We conducted a multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA) to assess whether personality and job context varied across boundary management profiles. See Table 11 for means and standard deviations. A statistically significant difference in personality and job characteristics based on boundary management clusters was found,  $F(30, 1834) = 3.68$ ,  $p < .001$ ; Wilk's  $\Lambda = 0.79$ , partial  $\eta^2 = .04$ . Follow-up ANOVAs indicated differences across clusters in all four personality and context variables examined: conscientiousness,  $F(5) = 6.90$ ,  $p < .01$ , neuroticism,  $F(5) = 4.60$ ,  $p < .01$ , responsibility for outcomes,  $F(5) = 8.34$ ,  $p < .01$ , and work structure,  $F(5) = 3.52$ ,  $p < .01$ .

Post hoc analyses were conducted to determine how the personality traits and job characteristic variables related to the clusters. The Tukey–Kramer Method was used due to the unequal sample sizes across clusters. Personal life prioritizers were higher in conscientiousness than overwhelmed reactors ( $p < .001$ ), flexible moderates ( $p < .01$ ), family guardians ( $p < .01$ ), and dividers ( $p < .001$ ). Personal life prioritizers and fusion lovers were not significantly different in their levels of conscientiousness. Dividers were significantly higher in neuroticism than personal life prioritizers ( $p < .05$ ) and flexible moderates ( $p < .01$ ). Family guardians were also significantly higher in neuroticism than flexible moderates ( $p < .05$ ).

For job characteristics, overwhelmed reactors had significantly greater responsibility for outcomes than family guardians ( $p < .05$ ). Flexible moderates also had greater responsibility for outcomes than personal life prioritizers ( $p < .01$ ), family guardians ( $p < .01$ ), and dividers ( $p < .01$ ). Flexible moderates also reported more unstructured work than personal life prioritizers ( $p < .01$ ).

## **Discussion**

The primary aim of this study was to gain a more comprehensive understanding of boundary management by examining the job characteristics and personality factors related to behaviours and capability for adopting certain styles. Using both self-report and objective occupational data, we found that both personality and job characteristics relate to individuals' boundary management styles, consequently contributing to boundary

theory (Ashforth et al., 2000) via the identification of factors that may impact the ease of role transitions.

First, considering work context, we found support for two of our three predicted associations between level of work responsibility and boundary management outcomes. Specifically, while responsibility of work outcomes was positively related to both work identity centrality and interruptions of non-work, no significant relationship was found between the variable and boundary control. One possibility for this lack of association may be an individual's ability to increasingly adapt their boundary management as their work responsibilities increase; longitudinal investigations of individual boundary management throughout one's career would best speak to such assertions. Overall, the current findings do suggest broadly that individuals with high versus low responsibility at work may manage boundaries in differing manners.

Beyond responsibility of work outcomes, we additionally investigated the role of work structure as related to employee boundary management. As compared to our findings relating to responsibility, our work structure findings received more limited support. Specifically, while increased work structure was indeed related to increased interruptions of work as predicted, our predictions surrounding boundary control or interruptions of non-work were not supported. Perhaps this lack of support found for the interruption of non-work is related to our measure's lack of differentiation between interruptions that are planned and welcomed, as compared to those that are unplanned and unwanted; the explicit examination of various interruption types (Jett & George, 2003) as predicted by work and personality characteristics would be a worthwhile future research endeavour. Despite certain unsupported associations, the results do broadly support the role of work characteristics (i.e., responsibility of outcomes and work structure) as related to employee boundary management, and suggest such variables as worthy of increased consideration in line with boundary theory's noting of the importance of the context in boundary flexibility and permeability.

The observed relationships between job characteristics and boundary management have several theoretical implications. First, although boundary management behaviours relate to individuals' preferences, our findings support that these behaviours may be constrained by the overarching job. In this study, we specifically identified and examined level of responsibility and job structure as job characteristic variables that had received prior theoretical and/or empirical investigation within the work-family literature; however, more work is needed to better understand additional aspects of the work environment that may play a role in enacted boundary management, including pressure from supervisor (Capitano & Greenhaus, 2018), social support from coworkers and supervisors, job involvement (Byron, 2005; Michel et al., 2011), and workplace norms (Palm, Seubert, & Glaser, 2019). Further investigations of the evolution of work characteristics across one's career trajectory (i.e., the potential for increased responsibility and decreased structure as one advances in roles) would also be beneficial.

Beyond work context variables, the present results also underscored the role of personality as related to boundary management. Considering first conscientiousness, the majority of hypothesized relationships were supported here, as conscientiousness was found to be associated with greater perceptions of boundary control, fewer cross-role interruptions in both directions, and greater family identity centrality (though, the relationship with work centrality was not significant). Further, our post hoc relative weights analyses suggested conscientiousness as the strongest predictor of our boundary management outcomes (Table 9), with explicit comparisons demonstrating the strength

**Table 11.** Personality and job characteristic differences between boundary management clusters

|                             | Overwhelmed reactors<br>(N = 65)<br><i>M(SD)</i> | Personal life prioritizers<br>(N = 11)<br><i>M(SD)</i> | Flexible moderates<br>(N = 50)<br><i>M(SD)</i> | Family guardians<br>(N = 128)<br><i>M(SD)</i> | Fusion lovers<br>(N = 159)<br><i>M(SD)</i> | Dividers<br>(N = 115)<br><i>M(SD)</i> |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Conscientiousness           | 8.96 (2.97)                                      | 11.02 (2.18)                                           | 9.68 (2.93)                                    | 9.54 (2.99)                                   | 9.00 (2.90)                                | 8.83 (2.63)                           |
| Neuroticism                 | 7.33 (5.67)                                      | 5.79 (5.26)                                            | 5.39 (5.14)                                    | 7.66 (5.30)                                   | 9.00 (5.60)                                | 8.60 (5.71)                           |
| Responsibility for outcomes | 3.60 (0.64)                                      | 3.37 (0.65)                                            | 3.77 (0.63)                                    | 3.27 (0.69)                                   | 3.35 (0.69)                                | 3.36 (0.75)                           |
| Work structure              | 4.35 (0.35)                                      | 4.23 (0.38)                                            | 4.41 (0.36)                                    | 4.29 (0.32)                                   | 4.24 (0.43)                                | 4.27 (0.42)                           |

*Note.* Replicated clusters are in non-italicized text. Newly proposed cluster names are italicized.

of conscientiousness in predicting interruptions of non-work as compared to work responsibility. Overall, the present findings largely support the importance of conscientiousness in worker boundary management enactment, and consequently inform boundary theory via the recognition of an important personal characteristic relevant to the creation and maintenance of work and non-work boundaries.

In contrast to our largely supported conscientiousness results, neuroticism only displayed relationships with interruptions of non-work (and not in the expected direction) and family identity centrality (although marginal associations with boundary control and interruptions of work were in the expected directions, and the relationship with boundary control emerged as significant once controlled for age). Regarding our unexpected finding with interruptions of non-work, it is possible that those high on neuroticism effortfully limit life interruptions in an attempt to exert control, though this speculation would benefit from further examination. It is further worthwhile to note that our measure of neuroticism may have been atypical; future work with more widely used measures of emotional stability would be useful as would focusing on facets (e.g., anxiety, vulnerability) rather than traits might elucidate clearer relationships. However, the present findings do broadly suggest that personality is indeed related to the manner in which individuals manage their work and non-work roles, particularly so in the case of conscientiousness.

The observed associations between personality and boundary management have several theoretical implications. One need is a clearer articulation of the causal role of personality. Besides the direct role of personality examined here, personality characteristics may have more distal and indirect influences on boundary management. That is, personality influences our job choices (Wang, Jome, Haase, & Bruch, 2006), and hence indirectly influences the work characteristics we have to contend with and the centrality of roles, which feed more directly into boundary management. Furthermore, while we focused on personality, it is likely that other individual characteristics may relate to boundary management behaviours, including ability and skill-based differences (perhaps those higher in cognitive ability manage roles differently than those lower on the construct), or motivational orientations (potentially those with avoidant orientations enact stricter role boundaries than those of approach orientations) or other personal characteristics (e.g., Spieler, Scheibe, and Stamo Robnagel (2018) found older workers set stronger boundaries).

In addition to our examination of boundary management as related to work context and individual difference variables, the second aim of the present study was to replicate the boundary management styles identified by Kossek et al.'s (2012) in a more job-diverse sample. We were able to replicate four out of six of Kossek et al.'s (2012) boundary management profile clusters, suggesting that there are styles of managing work-life interface that occur across many job types. The two clusters we were unable to replicate were 'work warriors' and 'non-work eclectics'. It is possible that we were unable to recreate 'work warriors' because our sample overall had less frequent interruptions of non-work ( $M = 1.99$ ,  $SD = 0.97$ ), and encompassed a wider range of jobs (as Kossek's et al's samples were only managerial). For 'non-work eclectics', our third cluster was similar with respect to cross-role interruptions and identity centrality, however different with respect to boundary control perceptions.

Our ability to replicate boundary management clusters has research implications, most prominently the value of considering boundary management characteristics together, rather than in isolation, using a person-centred approach (Kossek et al., 2012). Considering combinations of characteristics rather than concepts in isolation is not only

potentially more parsimonious, but it may be more helpful for intervention design and more intuitive to workers. It would be beneficial for future research to continue using a cluster approach (e.g. Capitano, DiRenzo, Aten & Greenhaus, 2017) to better understand the antecedents, outcomes, and boundary conditions of work–non-work management styles (e.g., Ammons, 2013) with respect to work-life and job outcomes.

### ***Practical implications***

While this study adds to our understanding of boundary management, it also has important implications for the workplace. If organizations want to help their employees with their boundary management, it is important to account for the context factors that affect boundaries in their work setting, as well as their personalities and preferences, all of which we found relate to boundary management. Work-life policies that are ‘one size fits all’ will not be effective for everyone and will not necessarily reduce work-life conflict, stress, or turnover. An intervention or policy meant to assist individuals with boundary management that ignores the constraints of job responsibilities and lack of autonomy may be seen by individuals as unrealistic or unhelpful. Our findings suggest that individual differences might affect responses to family-friendly policies. For example, if individuals low in conscientiousness tend to perceive lower boundary control, they may see instances of work–family conflict as unresolvable, or something they can do little about; interventions to highlight ways of gaining control may also include efforts to increase conscientious behaviour (i.e., planning helps one have less boundary management challenges). Further research on family-friendly policies should consider the role of individual differences and how that may subsequently influence both attitudinal and behavioural outcomes. If managers were able to work with employees individually to develop a useful boundary management strategy based on their job requirements and preferences, there may be a much greater impact. For example, managers could work with employees and discuss how their role responsibilities may shape their boundary management style, as well as their personal preferences. Through these conversations, managers can determine the best work-life arrangement for each employee (e.g., for some may be a compressed workweek, whereas for others could be flextime).

### ***Limitations***

It is important to note the limitations of this study. First, although data were multisource, they were cross-sectional. For that reason, we are unable to make any causal inferences about the relationship between personality, job characteristics, and boundary management characteristics. It is just as possible that individuals select jobs that fit their boundary management preferences or that individuals adapt their boundary management behaviours based on their context. Longitudinal research is needed to tease apart that relationship. Similarly, the research presented here does not allow us to infer that personality causes boundary management styles or vice versa; that is, it is entirely possible that individuals with high work centrality seek out jobs with greater responsibility. That being said, the stability of personality (Costa & McCrae, 1994; McGue, Bacon, & Lykken, 1993) suggests a reverse causal relationship is unlikely.

Second, we focused on job responsibilities and work structure, but factors such as the level of competition within a job, the amount of required facetime, the frequency of contact with others, and/or other interpersonal factors may warrant investigation. Theory building regarding what contextual factors influence boundary management could allow

for a systematic approach to selecting which contextual factors should be considered in future research.

Finally, although we investigated work characteristics at the job-level, the diversity of jobs within the dataset did not create sufficient nesting of individuals within jobs to warrant multilevel investigation. Future research could explore cultural, industry, and job-level differences in boundary management characteristics. For example, it would be interesting to explore how industry (i.e., manufacturing vs. retail) may play a role in individuals' boundary management behaviours.

## Conclusion

In sum, individuals differ in how they manage the work/non-work interface, potentially due in part to the context of their job, their personalities, and their personal preferences. Understanding these distinctions in boundary management styles can inform organizational policies, managerial decision-making on employee requests, and individual behaviours related to addressing work and non-work conflict.

## Conflicts of interest

All authors declare no conflict of interest.

## Author contributions

Danielle Gardner (Conceptualization; Formal analysis; Visualization; Writing – original draft; Writing – review & editing) Taylor Lauricella (Conceptualization; Data curation; Investigation; Project administration; Writing – original draft; Writing – review & editing) Ann Marie Ryan (Conceptualization; Project administration; Supervision; Writing – original draft; Writing – review & editing) Patrick Wadlington (Data curation; Funding acquisition; Project administration; Resources; Software; Supervision; Writing – review & editing) Fabian Elizondo (Data curation; Funding acquisition; Project administration; Resources; Software; Writing – review & editing).

## Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

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